

Mapping the route

There are four key stages that an idea must pass through before it enters the market or becomes a standard process. The first is the initial concept. A decision must be made as to whether the idea has the potential to benefit your organization, and whether the predicted costs merit further investment. The second stage is a detailed exploration of the practicalities—how the concept might work in practice, and, indeed, whether it is physically possible. At the same time, the concept must be developed so that you can discuss and share it with others, not least because along the way you'll have to convince some of them to provide funds, resources, and time to help you get it off the ground. The third phase is testing, which may include building a prototype, and researching how people in your target market (customers, clients, or coworkers) react to it. Finally, once testing is complete, the product can be launched, but even after launch its performance must be monitored to ensure your innovation provides the promised benefits.

Structuring the process

Managing an innovation through this process requires a well-defined structure, especially if you want to repeat the process and keep on generating and implementing new products, services, and processes. Not only must you establish each stage of the journey in detail, and provide a support structure to make sure your idea continues to progress, but you must also establish procedures for reviewing the project at each stage—and sometimes in between stages—to ensure that it remains on track and is still worth further investment. All of these procedures require resources, and your plan should include providing money, materials, and trained personnel to make innovation projects progress.

HOW TO... PLAN THE PROCESS

